

STILL HERE, STILL
HER

M K P A R R I S H

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Poems on surviving, softening, and staying.

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Still Here, Still Her

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First edition.

*For the woman who stayed —
and became.*

— MK



STILL HERE



On the days you only had to outlast.

INVENTORY

I counted what was left of me one morning:
two hands, still mine. A voice, a little hoarse.
A heart that kept its terrible appointment
and beat, and beat, without my permission.

Turns out that's a life. Turns out that's enough
to start from. I had been waiting to feel whole
before I'd call it living. I was already living.
I just hadn't looked up to take the count.

HOLDING PATTERN

Some seasons you don't bloom.

You just refuse to fall.

You keep your roots inside the dark
and call that faith. You let the cold
have the leaves but not the spine.

No one applauds a tree in winter.
And still — come spring — it's there.

THE SMALLER MERCIES

A full glass of water. A door that locks.

The particular gold of four o'clock
falling across the floor like it forgave me.

I learned to be grateful in miniature,
to take my healing in the size it came:
a good night's sleep, a joke that landed,
one whole hour I forgot to be afraid.

WHAT THE SCAR SAID

I used to hide it. Now I let it show.

It is the only honest line my body wrote
about the year I did not think I'd make.

It does not ask for pity. It just says:
here is where it tore, and here is where
it closed. Both true. Both mine. Still here.

OUTLASTING

I did not win. I did not lose. I stayed.

That was the whole achievement of those months —
to be, at the end of each one, not yet gone.

Survival is an unglamorous art.

No medals. No applause. Just the slow
astonishment of waking up again
and choosing, one more time, the harder yes.

ANCHOR

When everything was moving I found one
fixed thing — my own name, said out loud,
in my own voice, into the empty room.

Mary Kate. Still here. Still her.

I held to it like rope. The storm
did what storms do. The name did not let go.

THREE A.M.

The hour with no witnesses. The hour
the mind invents its worst and calls it true.
I learned to wait it out. To not believe
the things that only ever come at three.

Morning is also true, I'd tell myself.
Morning has a vote. Just hold until the vote.

PROOF OF LIFE

Here is the evidence: I am writing this.

Which means I rose. Which means I made the coffee.

Which means the worst night did not get the last word.

File it under proof. Keep it somewhere close.

On the next bad night, you'll want the record
that says: you've done this. You came back before.



STILL SOFTENING



On letting the hard parts become tender again.

THAW

I armored up to get through it.

That was wisdom, then. The trouble is
the armor doesn't know when it's over.

So now I'm teaching it. Now I'm saying:
you can set it down. You can be soft
in a safe room. You can let the warmth
reach all the way in. The war is done.

TENDERNESS IS NOT WEAKNESS

It takes more muscle to stay open
than to close. Any wall can hold a line.
It is the door that does the braver thing.

I want to be a door. I want to swing wide
for the right people and shut, kindly,
on the wrong ones — and call both love.

FORGIVING THE EARLIER ME

She did the best she could with what she knew,
which wasn't much, which was the whole of it.
I will not stand above her and keep score.

I lean back through the years and take her hand.
You got us here, I tell her. Look. We made it.
You can rest now. I've got the pen from here.

SOFT MORNINGS

I stopped waking like a soldier.

No more bracing at the alarm.

Now I let the light arrive first,

let the day make its small case

before I answer. Coffee. Quiet.

The radical idea that I am allowed
to begin gently. That I always was.

THE APOLOGY I STOPPED MAKING

I used to start each sentence small —
sorry for the space, sorry for the ask,
sorry for arriving with a need.

I'm unlearning the reflex. I take up room.
I let my wanting be a normal thing.
I save my sorry for when I've earned it.

SOFTEN, SHE SAID

Not collapse. Not surrender. Soften.

The way a fist becomes a hand again
and remembers it was made for holding.

I had forgotten. My whole body
had been a fist for years. Soften, she said.
And slowly, finger by finger, I did.

PERMISSION SLIP

I wrote one out, in my own hand, to me:
permitted to rest. Permitted to be wrong.
Permitted to change my mind in public.

I signed it. No one else was going to.
That was the lesson, in the end — the slip
I kept waiting for was mine to write.

UNCLENCH

My jaw. My shoulders. The grip behind my eyes.

I carried the bracing long past the need.

The body is loyal; it keeps the old orders.

So I give new ones now, soft and on purpose:

you're safe, you can lower your hands, you can breathe.

And slowly the old soldier stands down.



STILL HER



On becoming the woman you were writing toward.

THE AUTHOR

For years I read my life like it was given —
a script I had to honor, not revise.
Then someone asked: who told you that? And no one had.

I had been holding the pen the entire time.
I just hadn't dared to use it. So I did.
I crossed a line out. The sky did not fall.
I wrote a better one. And kept on writing.

BECOMING

I am not who I was. Good.

I am not yet who I'll be. Also good.

I live in the long middle of the verb,
in the -ing of it, the ongoing make.

Becoming is not a place you arrive.

It's the only honest place to live.

MY OWN NAME

I gave it back to myself like a gift
I'd been keeping for someone more deserving
and finally understood: she was me.

I say it now without apology.
It is not borrowed. It is not on loan.
It is the ground I'm building the rest on.

WALKING IN

The rooms I used to wait outside of —
I walk into them now. I don't knock twice.
I don't rehearse the right to be there.

I belong because I decided to belong,
which, it turns out, was always the only
permission that was ever going to come.

REWRITING

Every scar a sentence. Every stumble, a turn.
Every bridge I crossed and watched quietly burn
just smoke making room for a wider sky —
for the life that was restless, waiting, inside.

I am building a world from the ground of my name,
and the woman I'm becoming is why I came.

THE WOMAN IN THE GLASS

We have an understanding now, the two of us.

I no longer flinch. I no longer audit.

I meet her eyes and something settles.

You again, I say. Good. Stay.

She used to be a stranger I apologized to.

Now she is the one I'm building everything for.

SIGNATURE

There is a version of the story I'd sign
and a version I kept signing out of habit.
I can tell them apart now. That's the whole skill.

I only put my name to what is true.
Everything else I leave unsigned, undone —
a draft I'm free to never write again.

REINTRODUCTION

Hello. I don't think we've properly met.

I'm the one she was becoming the whole time,
the one the hard years were quietly making.

I'm late, I know. But I'm here now. For good.
Still here, against the odds. And — finally —
unmistakably, unapologetically, her.

CODA



The poem it all began with.

THE REWRITE

I picked up the pen and I felt the world shift,
the weight of a lifetime becoming a gift.
Every scar now a sentence, every stumble a turn,
every bridge that I crossed and watched quietly burn
just smoke making room for the sky opening wide,
for the story that's been living restless inside.

I am the author. I always have been.
I just had to believe in the plot I was in.

So I write myself boldly into what's new,
into rooms full of wonder I'm finally walking into.
I am building a life from the ground of my name
and the woman I'm becoming is the whole reason I came.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

MK Parrish is a writer, brand voice strategist, and author of *The Margins on Substack*. She writes about voice, identity, and the slow work of becoming. She lives in the long middle of the verb, and she is still — against everything — her.

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